

QUARRY TOWN

an invented screenplay
written for MARTINI's Day 14 demonstration

This screenplay, its characters, and its story
are entirely invented for a software demo. No
real film, studio, or person is depicted.

1 INT. FARMHOUSE KITCHEN - DAY

The kitchen table is buried under receipts and a ledger open to a page full of red ink. Rain taps the window over the sink. MARCUS stands over the table, still in yesterday's shirt. ELENA leans against the counter, arms crossed, coffee going cold in her hand.

MARCUS

You said the loan was covered through October.

ELENA

It was. Then the crusher needed a new belt, and the belt needed a guy who charges like it's surgery.

MARCUS

That's the third emergency this quarter.

ELENA

Funny how they keep finding us.

Marcus closes the ledger. Doesn't slam it. Worse -- he closes it gently, like he's already decided something and doesn't want her to see the decision on his face yet.

MARCUS

The crew's going to be at the gate in twenty minutes. I need a number I can say out loud to Desmond.

ELENA

Give him the number you'd give a stranger. Not the real one.

MARCUS

He's not a stranger.

ELENA

No. He's the one who'll ask a second question.

She sets the mug down, finally, and crosses to the table. Takes the ledger off it before Marcus can open it again.

ELENA (CONT'D)

Let's not let them see this face. Either of us.

2 INT. QUARRY OFFICE - DAY

A cramped trailer office, dust on every surface that isn't a keyboard. A space heater ticks in the corner though it's already warm outside. MARCUS holds out his hand. DESMOND doesn't move to meet it.

MARCUS

The keys, Desmond.

DESMOND

That truck's got a dozen problems the shop hasn't gotten to. Brakes pull left. You'll want the flatbed instead.

MARCUS

It's got one problem. You don't want to hand it over.
A beat. Desmond doesn't deny it.

DESMOND

Fine. It's got one problem.

MARCUS

I've had that truck inspected twice this year. Both times clean. So whatever's wrong with it isn't on the paperwork.

DESMOND

Some things don't show up on paperwork until they do.
Desmond looks at him a long moment, then digs the keys out of his jacket pocket and sets them on the desk between them -- not into his hand.

DESMOND (CONT'D)

Your call. Not mine anymore.

MARCUS

It was never yours. That's what I keep telling you.
Desmond doesn't answer that. Just holds the door for him on the way out.

3 EXT. RAIL CROSSING - DAY

Gravel shoulder, gates down, a freight train grinding past in the distance, longer than it needs to be. ELENA and JUNO wait in the truck's thin shadow, the engine still ticking as it cools.

JUNO

You were at the office past midnight. I saw the light from my window.

ELENA

Grown-up problems. Boring ones.

JUNO

You always say that right before it isn't boring.

ELENA

One day you'll get to have boring problems of your own. You'll understand the appeal.

JUNO

Is Dad okay?

ELENA

Your dad's fine. Everybody's fine.

The last car of the train clatters past. The gates begin to lift, slow and grinding.

JUNO

That's the second time you've said 'fine' like it's a whole sentence.

Elena doesn't answer -- just nods toward the truck as the crossing arm clears.

4 EXT. QUARRY ROAD - DAY

A dirt access road cut into the hillside, dust still hanging from an earlier haul truck. Orange flags mark the blast radius every twenty feet. DESMOND jogs to catch JUNO before the bend, out of breath in a way that isn't just from running.

DESMOND

Juno -- hold up. Not past the flags today. They're loading the north face at noon.

JUNO

I've walked that road a hundred times. I know where the flags usually are.

DESMOND

Not on a blasting day, you haven't. Humor me.

JUNO

You never care this much about the flags.

DESMOND

I care plenty. I just don't usually say so out loud. She stops. Looks at the flags, then at him -- reading something in how carefully he said it, something that isn't really about blasting schedules.

JUNO

You're being weird today. Everyone is.

DESMOND

It's that kind of day. Go around by the south gate. I'll walk you.

5 INT. QUARRY OFFICE - NIGHT

The same trailer, now lit by one desk lamp against a fully dark window. MARCUS, ELENA, and DESMOND stand in a loose triangle around the desk, none of them sitting, none of them quite looking at each other.

MARCUS

Six pages missing from the ledger. Not lost. Cut out with a blade, clean along the spine.

ELENA

And you're looking at me.

MARCUS

I'm looking at whoever had the drawer key last month. That's not an accusation, Elena. That's a fact with your name near it.

ELENA

There's a difference between near it and on it.

DESMOND

Maybe we table this until morning.

MARCUS

The bank doesn't do mornings, Desmond. The bank does numbers, and right now our numbers have a hole cut into them.

Nobody answers that directly. The lamp hums. Somewhere outside, a truck downshifts on the grade, and all three of them listen to it pass like it might be an answer.

5B INT. QUARRY OFFICE - NIGHT

MARCUS slides the ledger, whole again, across the desk to ELENA. Taps the page hard enough to make the lamp shiver.

MARCUS

Explain the numbers. Whatever you tell me, I'll believe it. That's how much I don't want this to be what it looks like.

ELENA

That's the problem. You will believe it. Whatever I say.

MARCUS

Is that a confession or a complaint?

ELENA

I don't know yet. Ask me again once I've said it out loud.

5C INT. QUARRY OFFICE - NIGHT

DESMOND steps forward before Elena can say more, putting himself squarely between the ledger and her.

DESMOND

It was me. The pages, the drawer key, all of it. She's been covering for me since March, and every version of this where she's the one explaining herself is the wrong version.

MARCUS

Since March.

DESMOND

Since March.

The silence that follows is worse than the accusation was -- long enough that the lamp's hum becomes the only sound in the room.

42 EXT. RESERVOIR EDGE - NIGHT

Water black under a thin moon, the far shore just a line of darker dark. ELENA and DESMOND sit on the tailgate, not touching, close enough that it doesn't matter.

DESMOND

I should've told you before Marcus did the math for us.

ELENA

You should've told me before there was math to do.

DESMOND

Would it have changed anything, if I had?

ELENA

No. That's what scares me about it.

DESMOND

Then what are we even fighting about.

ELENA

We're not fighting. We're just finally saying it outdoors instead of in that trailer.

She finally leans her head against his shoulder. Neither of them says anything else for a while -- the water doing enough of the talking, lapping at the tailgate's shadow.

42B INT. MARCUS'S TRUCK - NIGHT

Headlights sweep the quarry road in long arcs. MARCUS drives, both hands on the wheel like he's thinking through them. JUNO stares out the window at nothing in particular. The radio plays low, half static, tuned to a station that stopped coming in miles ago.

Marcus reaches once to change the station, thinks better of it, leaves it where it is.

The whole ride passes without a word between them -- the radio doing the only talking either of them can stand right now, static and all.

42C EXT. RESERVOIR PATH - NIGHT

ELENA walks the gravel path alone, hands in her jacket pockets, tracing the shoreline where the water meets the rock. She stops once, looks back at the office lights across the water -- small, steady, unbothered by any of it -- then keeps walking, slower now.

42D EXT. RESERVOIR EDGE - NIGHT

DESMOND, alone now, takes one last look out at the water before he cuts the truck's engine parked at the edge. The headlights die with it, one beam at a time.

The reservoir goes fully dark, and quiet, and still -- just the sound of the engine ticking as it cools, same as it did at the crossing that morning.

43 EXT. QUARRY GATE - DAY

Morning. The gate stands open, dew still on the chain-link. PRIYA gets out of a car that hasn't turned off, one hand still on the door like she isn't sure she's staying. MARCUS crosses the lot to meet her, slower than he needs to.

MARCUS

You said you'd call first.

PRIYA

I'm calling now. In person, so you can't hang up on me the way you hang up on everyone else lately.

MARCUS

Priya --

PRIYA

I'm selling my share, Marcus. Not today, not next week, but it's happening, and I wanted you to hear it from me before you heard it from the bank the way you hear everything else.

Marcus doesn't say anything at first. Behind them, the morning crew starts filing through the gate, giving the two of them a wide, deliberate berth -- the kind of berth people give a conversation they can tell isn't finished.

MARCUS

How long have you known?

PRIYA

Since before the ledger. This isn't about the ledger, and I need you to actually believe that.

MARCUS

Everything's been about the ledger for a month.

PRIYA

Not this. This has been coming since before there was anything to hide.

She finally lets go of the car door. It swings shut on its own weight, the sound flat in the morning air.

PRIYA (CONT'D)

It's about how long I've been standing at this gate telling myself it still feels like mine. It stopped feeling like mine a while ago, Marcus. I just didn't want to be the one who said it first.

A long beat. Marcus looks past her, out at the quarry -- the crusher, the office trailer, the reservoir just visible past the ridge -- like he's seeing all of it for the first time in years instead of the thousandth.

She starts toward the office. Marcus doesn't follow -- calls after her instead, and something in his voice makes her stop before she reaches the door.

MARCUS

Priya. Who's buying it?

PRIYA

Does it matter?

MARCUS

It matters to me whether I'm about to have a stranger's name on the deed next to mine.

She turns back around, and for a second the practiced calm she walked in with slips.

PRIYA

A holding company out of the county seat. I don't know the people behind it. I didn't ask, because I already knew I didn't want the answer to change my mind.

MARCUS

That's not like you. Not asking.

PRIYA

Maybe I'm tired of being the one who always asks the second question. You said it yourself about Desmond, about the keys. Maybe I wanted one decision in my life that didn't have a second question attached to it.

MARCUS

And if the answer's bad? If this holding company guts the place the second the ink's dry?

PRIYA

Then it guts a place I already let go of. That's the part you're not hearing. I let go of it before I ever picked up the phone to call the broker.

A long silence. Somewhere behind them, a truck horn sounds twice, someone waving the morning crew through the gate.

MARCUS

Does it. Still feel like yours, I mean. Even now, saying it all out loud to me.

PRIYA

Ask me again after I've sold it. Maybe I'll know by then. She starts toward the office again. This time Marcus lets her get three full steps before he speaks.

MARCUS

Dad would've hated this. Both of us standing at this gate talking about the place like it's a stranger's.

PRIYA

Dad hated a lot of things that turned out fine without him.

She stops at that, though -- doesn't turn around, just stops, one boot half in a puddle from last night's rain.

PRIYA (CONT'D)

I loved him. That's not the same as agreeing with every decision he made about this place, or every decision he expected the rest of us to keep making after he was gone.

MARCUS

Nobody's asking you to keep making his decisions.

PRIYA

Everybody's been asking me to keep making his decisions since the funeral. You just never noticed because you were the one asking loudest.

That lands. Marcus doesn't have a quick answer for it, and for once he doesn't reach for one.

MARCUS

I didn't know you felt that.

PRIYA

You didn't ask. Nobody asked. Everyone just assumed I'd keep showing up at this gate because I always had.

The morning crew has mostly filed through now, leaving the lot quiet except for the crusher starting somewhere behind the office, a low grinding hum that neither of them acknowledges.

PRIYA (CONT'D)

I'm not angry, Marcus. I want you to hear that part too. I'm just done being the one who shows up out of habit instead of choice.

MARCUS

And selling is a choice.

PRIYA

It's the first one I've made about this place in ten years that actually feels like mine. Even if it means it stops being mine the second the papers are signed.

She walks past him, toward the office, without waiting for an answer -- the same way she's walked into every hard conversation this place has ever handed her.